and fear. The last one happened on 9 August, days before the ceasefire, where several right-wing protesters were photographed holding signs that read, in Hebrew, “one people, one state, one leader”—a translation of the famous Nazi propaganda slogan “*ein Volk, ein Reich, ein Fuhrer”*. Standing in the background of one of the photos, surrounded by his lions, was The Shadow.

Death

During the brief 2012 conflict, I interviewed David Bouskila, the mayor of Sderot, a frontline town on the Gaza border. He raved about the success of the Iron Dome system: since it went online in mid-2011, he said, “just two or three” rockets had hit his town, compared to thousands in the preceding years. Ten minutes later, just a hundred meters down the road from where we spoke, a rocket crashed into a house. It was a small, unsophisticated projectile that caused only minor damage and no injuries, though it terrified the inhabitants. I ran into Bouskila again outside the home. “I need to update those figures I gave you,” he said with a wry grin.

The Home Front Command, the branch of the Israeli army that handles civilian preparedness, issues a color-coded map that shows people how much time they have to find shelter once the air-raid siren sounds. The towns in the “Gaza envelope”, marked in bright red, have less than fifteen seconds, if they get any warning at all. Mortars rarely show up on radar, so the first indication of incoming fire is the sound of a nearby explosion and the disorienting crash of a blast wave. The roads in Sderot are lined with bomb shelters, which look like bus stops made of concrete. Life there was intolerable for years.

By 2014, though, the threat of rockets was significantly diminished, thanks to Iron Dome, an extensive network of sirens and shelters, and the general shoddiness of Hamas’ arsenal. In the first month of the war, they caused three deaths, all of them essentially preventable: the Jewish man killed on the border while delivering food to soldiers; an Israeli Bedouin, from a village with no sirens or bomb shelters; and a migrant worker from Thailand, fatally wounded by shrapnel while working in an open field. More Israeli civilians were killed by traffic accidents that summer than by rockets. But the threat was not completely neutralized.